Heuristic Evaluation - IAT 334

AllTrails Group Event Feature

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Method	Expert review against Nielsen's 10 Heuristics
Scope	13 screens Host flow, Join flow, Community feed, Saved Events
Date	October 5 2023

Severity Scale

Rating	Label	Meaning
S1	Cosmetic	Fix if time allows
S2	Minor	Low priority fix in next design pass
S3	Major	High priority impacts task completion
S4	Critical	Blocks task completion or damages trust

H1 Visibility of System Status

The system should always keep users informed about what is going on.

1.1 Step indicator correctly shows 4-step host flow progress — No Issue

Steps 1-4 are visible and the active step is clearly distinguished. Users know where they are and how far they have to go. No action required.

1.2 No confirmation state after tapping Join on an event card — S3

After a participant taps Join on the event detail sheet, there is no designed screen showing what happened. The flow routes directly to Saved Events but the transition is abrupt and leaves the user without feedback that their action succeeded.

Recommended fix: A brief inline confirmation "You're in. Check Saved Events for updates" closes the feedback loop before routing.

1.3 Occupancy ratio communicates availability but not urgency — S2

Showing 3/10 is correct. At 9/10 or when full, the visual treatment should change a warning colour on the ratio or an "Almost full" label to communicate urgency without requiring the user to calculate remaining capacity.

H2 Match Between System and the Real World

The system should speak the users' language and follow real-world conventions.

2.1 Got a code? is clear and conversational — No Issue

The label matches how users would naturally refer to having received a private invite code. No action required.

2.2 Time format inconsistent across screens — S2

Some screens display 24-hour format (18:00) while others use 12-hour with AM/PM (09:00 A.M). The inconsistency forces users to mentally convert between formats.

Recommended fix: Standardise to 12-hour AM/PM throughout. This matches the convention for consumer outdoor apps in most target markets.

2.3 Hosted by You in Saved Events is accurate natural language — No Issue

Correctly distinguishes events the user is managing from events they are attending, without requiring a separate label system. No action required.

H3 User Control and Freedom

Users need clearly marked emergency exits.

3.1 Cancel is present on all host flow steps — No Issue

Every step of the 4-step host flow has a Cancel button that exits the flow. This is correctly implemented.

3.2 No undo after tapping Post — S3

Once the host taps Post on the public confirm screen, the event goes live immediately. The success state does not show a clearly accessible cancel option. If a host posted with incorrect details wrong date, wrong trail they have no recovery path without navigating away and finding a management screen.

Recommended fix: Verify that the Manage Event screen includes a cancel/delete event action. If it does not, add it. Consider adding an inline undo link on the success screen: "Posted in error? Cancel this event."

3.3 Sheet dismissal loses data without warning — S2

A user who swipes down on the host flow bottom sheet mid-completion loses all entered data with no warning. This is a standard mobile pattern failure on multi-step forms.

Recommended fix: A dismissal confirmation "Leave event setup? Your progress will be lost" prevents accidental data loss. This is especially important after Step 2 when the user has already invested time in the flow.

H4 Consistency and Standards

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing.

4.1 Confirm and post vs Review the details on structurally identical screens — S2

The public confirm screen says "Confirm and post." The private confirm screen says "Review the details." Both screens share identical structure trail photo, metadata grid, Modify and action button. The heading distinction is intentional (Post terminates the public flow; Next continues the private flow) but may confuse users who complete both flows at different times.

Recommended fix: Consider unifying both headings to "Review the details" and letting the button label carry the path distinction entirely.

4.2 Join CTA uses inconsistent visual treatment across screens — S2

The Join button on community feed event cards uses a white filled pill. The Join button on the event detail sheet uses dark green filled. The same primary action has two different visual encodings depending on context, which undermines the semantic consistency of the button system.

Recommended fix: Standardise Join to dark green filled throughout. Reserve white fill exclusively for the segmented control selected state.

4.3 Selected segmented control state is consistent with primary CTA treatment — No Issue

The dark green filled selected pill matches the primary button colour system. This was resolved through iteration and is correctly implemented.

H5 Error Prevention

Design to prevent problems from occurring.

5.1 Native date and time pickers prevent formatting errors — No Issue

The shift from free-text inputs to native pickers eliminates the primary error vector on Step 1. This is a significant improvement from the original design and eliminates an entire class of validation problems.

5.2 No validation if activity not selected before Continue — S3

The segmented control on Step 1 defaults to unselected. If a user taps Continue without selecting Hiking or Biking, the system behaviour is undefined. Allowing progression without an activity type selected would result in an event posting with missing data.

Recommended fix: An inline validation state segmented control border highlights in red, message appears: "Please select an activity type" must be designed before development handoff.

5.3 Group size range not communicated on Step 2 — S2

The dropdown defaults to 10. Users do not know if 1 is the minimum or if 100 is available. Without a visible range, users may attempt to select values the system does not support.

Recommended fix: Show the valid range as helper text "Select between 2 and 50 attendees" directly below the dropdown.

5.4 No invalid code error state for Got a code? entry **S3**

If a user enters an incorrect or expired join code, there is no designed error state. This is a functional gap that blocks the private event join path entirely when it fails.

Recommended fix: Design an inline error state for the code entry sheet: "That code doesn't match any event. Check with your host and try again." This must be specced before development.

H6 Recognition Rather Than Recall

Minimise the user's memory load.

6.1 Trail photo anchored throughout the host flow **No Issue**

The selected trail photo appears across all host flow steps, the confirm screen, and the success state. Users never have to remember which trail they selected it is always visible. This is a strong implementation of recognition over recall.

6.2 Share icons on success screens are unlabelled **S2**

WhatsApp and iMessage icons are broadly recognised. The chain link icon for copy link is less universally understood, particularly for users less familiar with mobile conventions.

Recommended fix: Add a small label below each share icon WhatsApp, Message, Copy link to remove the recognition dependency.

H7 Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Accelerators allow expert users to move faster.

7.1 No shortcut for repeat hosts **S2**

A host who runs weekly group hikes on the same trail will repeat the same 4-step flow every time with only minor date changes. There is no Host Again or Duplicate Event shortcut in Saved Events.

Recommended fix: Add a "Host again" action on past events in the Saved Events list. This reduces a 4-step flow to a 1-step action for the most engaged host users, which directly supports retention.

H8 Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Dialogues should not contain irrelevant or rarely needed information.

8.1 Event detail sheet contains all decision-relevant information without excess — No Issue

Trail photo, location, time, date, activity, occupancy ratio, Cancel and Join. Nothing extraneous. The sheet is correctly scoped to the decision the participant needs to make.

8.2 Contextual lines on success screens are correctly minimal — No Issue

"This is a public event, meaning anyone can join from the community page" is one sentence that carries the necessary information without over-explaining. Correctly implemented on both public and private success states.

8.3 Best Views nearby label misaligned with host task context — S1

The Host tab shows a trail list under the heading "Best Views nearby" a discovery-oriented label. For a user in the process of choosing a trail to host an event on, this framing is aspirational rather than functional.

Recommended fix: "Trails nearby" or "Choose a trail" would be more appropriate at this decision point. Low priority cosmetic change.

H9 Help Users Recognise, Diagnose, and Recover From Errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language and suggest a solution.

9.1 No error states designed for any flow across all 13 screens — S3

Across all 13 screens, there are no error states. This is the most significant systemic gap in the current design. The following failure scenarios are unaddressed:

- Invalid or expired join code entry
- Network failure during event posting
- Event reaches full capacity between the user viewing it and tapping Join
- Activity type not selected before tapping Continue on Step 1

Recommended fix: Before development handoff, error states must be designed for all four scenarios above at minimum. Error messages should be written in plain language and suggest a specific next action.

H10 Help and Documentation

Help should be easy to search and focused on the user's task.

10.1 No onboarding or first-use guidance for the Host flow S2

A first-time host entering the 4-step flow has no orientation to what they are creating, what hosting means in this context, or what the outcome will be. This increases the likelihood of abandonment on first attempt.

Recommended fix: A single introductory screen or tooltip before Step 1 "You're setting up a group event. Choose the details and we'll list it for others to join." reduces uncertainty for new hosts without adding significant friction for returning ones.

Summary of Findings

#	Finding	Heuristic	Severity
1.2	No post-join confirmation state	H1 System Status	S3
1.3	Occupancy ratio has no urgency signal at capacity	H1 System Status	S2
2.2	Time format inconsistent across screens	H2 Real World	S2
3.2	No undo/cancel after Post	H3 User Control	S3
3.3	Sheet dismissal loses data without warning	H3 User Control	S2
4.2	Join CTA inconsistent visual treatment	H4 Consistency	S2
5.2	No validation if activity not selected	H5 Error Prevention	S3
5.3	Group size range not communicated	H5 Error Prevention	S2
5.4	No invalid code error state	H5 Error Prevention	S3
6.2	Share icons unlabelled	H6 Recognition	S2
7.1	No repeat host shortcut	H7 Flexibility	S2
8.3	Best Views label misaligned with host task	H8 Minimalist	S1
9.1	No error states designed for any flow	H9 Error Recovery	S3
10.1	No first-use guidance for host flow	H10 Help	S2

Stakeholder Recommendation

Five S3 findings represent the highest priority before development handoff:

- 1.2 Post-join confirmation state missing
- 3.2 No undo/cancel path after posting a public event
- 5.2 Activity selection has no validation state
- 5.4 Invalid code entry has no error state
- 9.1 No error states designed for any flow

These are not visual refinements. They are missing functional states that will cause user failure in production. Each S3 finding maps to a user action that has no designed resolution when it goes wrong.

The nine S2 findings are addressable in a subsequent design pass without blocking development on the core flows. The single S1 finding is cosmetic and can be deferred to a future iteration.

The core host and join flows are structurally sound. The information architecture, step sequencing, visual consistency, and primary interaction patterns have been resolved through iteration. The remaining work is failure state coverage designing for what happens when things go wrong, not just when they go right.